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THA 111: Introduction to Drama and Theatre in the World

The concepts and vocabularies you need before every other theatre course

THEATRE & FILM

Theatre & Film Studies

Faculty of Arts
Theatre & Film Studies | 100L

OUTLINE ARCHIVE: 2018 - 2019 - 2025/2026

Written for students, by students.

Practical notes, worked examples, practice questions and a revision plan.

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Why this pack exists

This course exists to stop you using 'drama', 'theatre', 'performance' and 'play' as if they mean the same thing. The pack sets out the working distinctions, traces the move from ritual to built theatres, and gives you a vocabulary for discussing any performance tradition in the world.

This is a student-written study companion, not a reproduced lecture handout or a leaked examination paper. Use it to organise the topics you are taught, practise the kind of thinking your course rewards, and walk into class with better questions.

What you will be able to do

- Distinguish drama as text from theatre as performance event.
- Trace the shift from ritual and festival performance to purpose-built theatre buildings.
- Identify the social conventions that shape performance in different periods.
- Use genre and structural terms accurately in written answers.

How to use this pack

1. Skim the whole pack once in 20 minutes so you know what is inside.
2. Work through one section at a time with your lecture note and recommended text beside you.
3. Attempt the practice questions before reading the answers. Mark what you missed.
4. Use the final checklist to plan your revision week, one tick per study session.

> **Free to download, always**
> This pack is free. There is no fee, no subscription and no payment step before download, and the full PDF is not watermarked or locked. Share the link with a coursemate instead of forwarding the file.

> **Confirm your official course outline**
> Course codes, credit units and outlines can differ by department and session. Treat this pack as supplementary support and confirm the current outline with your lecturer, course rep or departmental handbook before an assessment.

Four terms that are not synonyms

Precise vocabulary earns marks and prevents confused essays.

- Drama: the written or composed work, its structure, character and dialogue.
- Theatre: the collaborative event, including performers, space, audience and technology.
- Performance: the broader category of staged human action, including dance and ritual.
- Play: usually a dramatic text; a production is one realisation of it.
- Text and production can differ sharply: a director's choices are an interpretation, not a copy.

From ritual to theatre house

The institution of theatre grew out of communal performance and accumulated its own conventions.

- Greek festival theatre: civic competition, masks, chorus and open-air amphitheatre.
- Roman spectacle: larger structures, entertainment politics and a shift in audience composition.
- Medieval religious drama: pageant wagons, guild cycles and church calendar.
- Asian traditions: Noh, Kabuki and Sanskrit theatre developed their own conventions rather than following Europe.
- African festival theatre retained participatory structures that European proscenium theatre reduced.
- Each built form encodes a social relation between performer and audience.

> **The proscenium is an argument**
> A proscenium arch separates performers from spectators. That separation is a historical choice, not a neutral default, and it changes what performance can do.

Talking about structure and genre

Use these terms with a definition and an example.

- Plot, character, thought, diction, song and spectacle: Aristotle's six elements, still useful as an analysis checklist.
- Tragedy, comedy, tragicomedy, farce, satire and melodrama: know the conventions that define each.
- Conflict, complication, climax and resolution: describe structure rather than retelling plot.
- Dramatic irony: the audience knows what a character does not.
- Convention: an agreed shorthand the audience accepts, from soliloquy to puppetry.

Text, performance and the gap between them

A play script is an incomplete document. It records dialogue and some stage directions, but it leaves casting, tempo, spatial arrangement, lighting, sound and the audience relationship to a production. Two directors staging the same script can produce events that feel unrelated.

This is why "the play" is ambiguous. Drama is the composed work; theatre is an event that exists only while it is happening. When an exam asks you to discuss a play, check which object it means: the text, a specific production, or the idea of the work across productions. Confusing the three produces answers that drift between literary analysis and reviewing.

A useful habit is to separate three questions. What does the text require? What did this production choose? What did those choices do to the meaning? Answering only the first is a literature answer, not a theatre answer.

The six elements and what they are for